

PFIZER FULL SCRIPT

Title Slide – “Pfizer: Organizational Behavior in Crisis” | SHIVALI

“Good morning/afternoon everyone — we’re excited to walk you through how Pfizer tackled one of the biggest global challenges of our time — not just with science, but with strategy, leadership, and people.

We’re your presenters: I’m Shivali, and with me are Chintan, Manideep, Jahnavi and Vinay. Each of us will walk you through different parts of Pfizer’s journey, using our lens of Organizational Behavior.”

Introduction – “Pfizer’s Moonshot Moment” | SHIVALI

“To start things off — picture this: it’s early 2020, the world is in crisis, and a vaccine feels like a distant hope.

Pfizer doesn’t wait for funding or government guarantees — they take a \$2 billion gamble and self-fund the entire R&D process. Their mission? Get a safe, effective vaccine to market in record time.

But what made it possible wasn’t just science. It was how the organization operated — how teams collaborated, how leaders stepped up, how decisions were made — that’s where OB comes in.”

W3

First, we look at transformational and charismatic leadership—how CEO Albert Bourla’s bold vision and trust-based leadership style galvanized the company around a singular purpose.

Next, we’ll explore team dynamics and communication, showing how Pfizer built psychological safety and fostered collaboration across self-managed, cross-functional teams—despite the remote work transition. Then we’ll examine motivation and organizational culture, focusing on how Pfizer aligned intrinsic purpose with performance rewards to keep morale high during long, uncertain months. We’ll also address ethical leadership and conflict resolution, which became particularly important as Pfizer faced external pressure around vaccine equity and internal tensions between speed and regulatory compliance.

From there, we move into diversity and change management—exploring how Pfizer prioritized inclusivity in clinical trials and applied classic change models to ensure a seamless digital transformation during remote work.

Each of these six aspects didn't just contribute to vaccine development—they created the foundation for sustained organizational resilience.

And with that, I'd now like to hand it over to Vinay, who will take us deeper into the first component: transformational and charismatic leadership, and how Albert Bourla's strategic and behavioral decisions shaped Pfizer's crisis response."

Leadership – “Bourla’s Bold Call” | MANIDEEP

"Pfizer’s CEO, Albert Bourla, showed transformational leadership. He approved a \$2 billion internal investment for vaccine R&D — before any government contract was in place. That’s a bold, visionary move. His phrase ‘Science will win’ became a unifying message across the company.

He also used bounded rationality when selecting BioNTech as a partner. Instead of months of analysis, they moved quickly — using best judgment under time constraints, which paid off.

On teamwork — Pfizer transformed their internal structure. Instead of rigid hierarchies, they created self-managed, cross-functional teams that collaborated across departments like R&D, logistics, and compliance.

Tools like Slack and Microsoft Teams enabled real-time decisions, while fast feedback loops kept innovation moving. Most important was psychological safety — employees felt free to speak up, challenge ideas, and contribute fully. That’s a big part of what made these teams so effective."

Teamwork – “Agile, Empowered, and Aligned” | VINAY

“Now let’s talk teams — and this is where Pfizer really broke the mold. Instead of traditional silos, they formed agile, cross-functional teams. These weren’t your standard top-down operations. Teams were self-managed, fast-moving, and tech-enabled — using tools like Slack, Teams, and shared dashboards to collaborate in real-time.

More importantly, psychological safety was encouraged — meaning people could speak up, challenge decisions, and admit mistakes without fear. That made a huge difference under pressure.”

Culture & Motivation – “Mission Meets Metrics” | VINAY

“So how did they keep people motivated while working around the clock? It wasn’t just bonuses or promotions — though those were there.

At its core, Pfizer’s culture was driven by purpose. Employees were engaged by the humanitarian mission — the sense that they were doing something truly meaningful. [Point to bar graph] As shown here, employee engagement rose from 70% in 2019 to 88% in 2021 — a direct result of OB-aligned motivation strategies.

That alignment between mission and motivation helped fuel their performance at every level.”

Ethics & Conflict Resolution – “Speed Without Compromise” | JAHNAVI

"Diversity wasn't just a talking point at Pfizer — it was operationalized. In the U.S. Phase 3 vaccine trials, [point to bar graph] 42% of participants were from underrepresented racial and ethnic groups. That diversity helped build public trust in the vaccine's fairness and safety. Internally, Pfizer trained over 80,000 employees in unconscious bias, and D&I was built into leadership programs. According to social identity theory, feeling represented boosts engagement — and that's exactly what Pfizer achieved.

Change management was also key. They followed Lewin's 3-Step Model — first unfreezing old silos, then implementing hybrid teams and digitized processes, and finally refreezing those innovations into new SOPs.

Their Digital Operations Center is a result of this — it institutionalized agile, data-driven decision-making, which continues to benefit Pfizer today."

Critique & Recommendations – “What Could’ve Gone Better?” | CHINTAN

“Alright, so Pfizer’s response to the pandemic was honestly remarkable, but it wasn’t flawless — and that’s what we’re looking at here.

One of the biggest issues was burnout. When you’re working 24/7 to deliver a vaccine to the world, that takes a serious toll. Teams were under intense pressure for months — and while the mission was critical, it came at a cost.

Another challenge was that some mid-level managers lacked emotional intelligence — and in a crisis, EQ matters just as much as IQ. People needed to feel heard, supported, and motivated — not just pushed to hit deadlines.

So what can Pfizer learn from this?

First, mental health support needs to be proactive — not reactive. Whether that’s counseling, flexible hours, or mandatory rest periods, people perform better when they’re mentally okay. But here’s the thing — it depends on the individual needs of the team members and the work environment. There’s no one-size-fits-all solution here.

Second, emotional intelligence training could go a long way, especially for people leading teams.

And last — as they scale up global operations — it’s worth expanding diversity and inclusion efforts, especially through their supply chain, and investing in better forecasting tools to stay ahead of future disruptions. Basically — amazing job, but there’s always room to grow.”

Conclusion – “Why This Case Really Matters” | CHINTAN

“So if we take a step back — this case is about much more than vaccines. What Pfizer showed us is how powerful organizational behavior can be when it’s aligned with purpose.

From bold leadership, to building a high-performance culture, to working with urgency but not losing sight of ethics — they balanced it all.

And in doing so, they didn’t just lead in science — they led in behavior, too.

So whether you’re running a pharma giant or managing a small startup, the core takeaway here is:

➤ *Invest in your people,* ➤ *Lead with purpose,* ➤ *And never underestimate the power of OB during a crisis."*

References – "Closing Notes" | CHINTAN

"That wraps it up — here are the references we pulled everything from. Thanks so much for listening — we're happy to take any questions you have!"

Concept	Chapter	Where It Appears
Transformational Leadership	Chapter 12: Leadership	Leadership & Vision section
Charismatic Leadership	Chapter 12: Leadership	Leadership section
Bounded Rationality	Chapter 6: Perception and Decision-Making	Decision-Making Under Pressure section
Self-Managed Teams	Chapter 9: Foundations of Group Behavior	Team Dynamics section
Psychological Safety	Chapter 9/11 (Teams & Communication)	Team Dynamics and Communication
Open Communication	Chapter 11: Communication	Communication section
Expectancy Theory	Chapter 7: Motivation	Motivation section
Goal-Setting Theory	Chapter 7: Motivation	Motivation section
McClelland's Theory of Needs	Chapter 7: Motivation	Motivation section
Ethical Leadership	Chapter 14: Leadership Ethics	Ethical Leadership section
Task Conflict and Resolution	Chapter 14/Conflict Frameworks	Ethical Leadership section
Diversity and Inclusion	Chapter 3: Attitudes and Diversity	D&I and Structural Change section
Lewin's Change Model	Chapter 18: Organizational Change	Organizational Change section
Emotional Intelligence	Chapter 4: Emotions and Moods	Critique & Recommendations section